Hindutva sentiment is not new in Indian politics. The big question to ask is: why did the BJP never win such victories before? Even at the height of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, in 1989, the Communist Party of India (CPI) beat the BJP at the epicentre of the movement, in Ayodhya, when its Mitrasen Yadav was elected as an MP. 'Even when the Mandir movement was at its peak, temple politics did not always win in Ayodhya itself. At that time, when sentiments around Ram were at their peak, caste consciousness beat Mandir politics in the Faizabad seat in Ayodhya with the victory of a Yadav candidate,' points out senior Lucknow-based journalist Pranshu Mishra.[9] The BJP's vote share was lower than the combined votes of the socialist and pro-Dalit parties and Congress in UP's provincial elections, even in 1991.[10]

The master key, as BJP's campaign managers recognised after 2014, is the politics of welfare and caste representation. At Lucknow's Lok Bhawan, where Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath functions from, a senior official working closely with him pointed this out to me as he explained the chaupal outreach programme: 'The BJP vote base basically is a mindset that we call Hindutva. This gives speed [gati] but the job of spinning the wheel is direct benefit transfers, social benefits, this is it. *Hindutva is like the elephant's teeth. The real teeth is welfare. Hindutva gives you speed if you are going in a particular direction, but welfare is the wheel that makes it all run* [emphasis added].'[11] Importantly, 'welfare' or 'development' here is not used in its usual sense of building 'hard infrastructure' but rather the redistribution of direct individual benefits using cash transfers through a dozen-plus schemes streamlined and funded by the Union government. How its leaders embraced this changed the party as a political outfit and created what can be called a new BJP system of politics. This new model is fundamentally different from what has been called the Congress 'system', which was based on a politics of 'consensus' and underpinned its political dominance in India from the 1950s to the 1990s.[12]